

DON'T DIE RETIRED

Slow Travel After 50

The trip-planning workbook for longer, calmer, better journeys

Planning workbook · £12

dontdieretired.com

This workbook is general information, not medical, financial or legal advice. Entry requirements, health advice and insurance terms change and depend on your destination and circumstances. Check current official guidance before booking: in the UK, [gov.uk](https://gov.uk/foreign-travel-advice) foreign travel advice and NHS Fit for Travel; in the US, travel.state.gov and CDC Travelers' Health.

Slow Travel After 50

A workbook for planning one good, unhurried trip: a week to a month in one place, reached by train where the train makes sense, with time to walk, to sit, to get to know a bakery and a bench. It is for people over fifty who have more time than they used to, a body that prefers not to be rushed, and no interest in seeing eleven cities in ten days.

Slow travel is not a style or a slogan. It is a set of practical choices: fewer destinations, longer stays, surface travel where you can, the quiet months rather than the crowded ones, and a daily rhythm you could keep up for a month without needing a holiday to recover from the holiday. Done well it is often cheaper than the usual kind, kinder on the knees and the planet, and considerably more memorable, because you were actually there long enough to notice things. This is a workbook, not a guidebook. Print it, write in it, and fill in the blanks. By the end you will have chosen a trip that fits you, costed it honestly, sorted insurance and health preparation properly, packed one bag, and worked through a twelve-week countdown so that the last week before departure is calm rather than frantic. There is a weekly rhythm for the trip itself and a short page for when you get home.

How this workbook is organised

- **Part 1: Choosing a trip that fits.** A decision table, eight kinds of slow trip, and a worksheet to pin down the one you will actually take.
- **Part 2: Money, beds and trains.** A budget template, long-stay accommodation options, and rail passes explained at the level you need before you look at the official pages.
- **Part 3: Insurance and health.** Declaring conditions honestly, what a GHIC (the UK's free health card for Europe) does and does not do, what US travellers need to know about Medicare abroad, and health preparation that starts six to eight weeks out.
- **Part 4: The practical layer.** Packing light, staying connected, safety and scams.
- **Part 5: Travelling your way.** Solo after fifty, limited mobility, travelling with grandchildren, walking holidays, house-sitting and home exchange, and the off-season.
- **Part 6: Keeping well and keeping a record.** Fitness on the road, journaling and photography.
- **The 12-week countdown,** an on-trip weekly rhythm, and a homecoming page.

A note on rules, prices and health

Entry requirements, passport rules, health advice and insurance terms change, and they depend on where you are going and on your own circumstances. Everything here is general information to help you know what to check and what to ask. Before you book, check the official pages for your own country and destination: in the UK, gov.uk foreign travel advice and NHS Fit for Travel; in the US, travel.state.gov and CDC Travelers' Health. Where this workbook quotes a figure, it was correct on the official page when we read it; confirm it before you rely on it.

Part 1: Choosing a trip that fits

The biggest decision is not where. It is what kind of trip your body, your budget and your temperament will actually enjoy for three weeks. Get that right and the destination almost chooses itself.

Score each row from 1 (not really) to 5 (very much). Do it honestly and, if you are travelling with someone, do it separately and then compare. The rows with high scores point you towards certain kinds of trip; the table after this one shows which.

Worksheet 1: what I want from this trip	Me (1 to 5)	Companion (1 to 5)
I want to unpack once and stay put		
I want to walk most days, properly		
I want to avoid airports altogether if I can		
I want to keep costs low over a long stay		
I want to be somewhere with few other visitors		
I want easy access: few steps, short distances, reliable transport		
I want to travel alone and meet people on my own terms		
I want to bring grandchildren for some or all of it		
I want warmth and light in the darker months		
I want to learn something (a language, a craft, a landscape)		

Eight kinds of slow trip

Kind of trip	Suits you if you scored high on	Watch out for
One town, one month (an apartment in a small city or large village)	Unpack once; keep costs low; learn something	Choosing somewhere with nothing to do on a wet Tuesday. Pick a place with a market, a library, a walking group or a class.
Rail journey with long stops (three or four places, a week in each, by train)	Avoid airports; unpack once (mostly); learn something	Too many stops. Three is plenty. Reservations on high-speed and night trains often cost extra.
Walking holiday (a route walked over one to two weeks, or a base with day walks)	Walk properly; few visitors; warmth and light (in the right season)	Overestimating daily distance. Walk the planned daily distance at home first, several times.
House-sitting or home exchange	Keep costs low; unpack once; few visitors	Obligations (pets, plants, neighbours) that shape your days. Read the listing as a job description.
Off-season stay (a summer place in spring or autumn; a ski village in June)	Few visitors; keep costs low; warmth and light	Closed restaurants, reduced buses, short daylight. Check what is actually open.
Solo stay with structure (a course, a volunteer placement, a language school with homestay)	Travel alone; learn something	Structure that becomes a timetable. Leave whole days free.

Kind of trip	Suits you if you scored high on	Watch out for
Accessible base (a well-connected town, ground-floor or lift accommodation, flat terrain)	Easy access; unpack once	Listings that say 'accessible' without detail. Ask precise questions, in writing, before paying.
Three generations, one house (a large rental with grandchildren for part of the stay)	Bring grandchildren; unpack once	Everyone's needs at once. Plan the grandchildren's week as a separate block with its own rhythm.

Rail or air? A plain test

Add up the door-to-door time by each, including getting to the airport early, queues, and the journey in from the airport at the other end. For many journeys within the UK, within Europe, and along the busier corridors of the US, a train of five to eight hours competes with a flight once those are included, and you arrive in the middle of the city, rested, with your luggage. Beyond about a day's rail travel, break the journey with a night's stop rather than pressing on. The stop becomes part of the trip.

Worksheet 2: my trip, in one place	Your answer
The kind of trip (from the eight above)	
Where (one place, or up to three with a week each)	
How long, and which month	
How I will get there (rail / ferry / car / air, and why)	
Who is coming, for which part	
What a good ordinary day there looks like	
What I want to be able to say I did, by the end	
One thing I will deliberately not try to do	

Part 2: Money, beds and trains

A long stay in one place costs less per day than a short one, but the total is larger and the money goes out in different ways. This part gives you a budget template, the accommodation options that work for weeks rather than nights, and a plain explanation of rail passes.

Fill in your own figures. We have deliberately left the 'typical' column mostly blank: prices vary so much by country, season and standard that any number printed here would mislead someone. Where a figure appears it was taken from an official page at the time of writing and should be checked. Use the last column to record what you actually spent, because the second slow trip is always better costed than the first.

Item	Typical range (fill in from your own research)	My estimate	Actual
Travel there and back (rail, ferry, fuel, flights)			
Rail pass or point-to-point tickets during the trip			
Seat and sleeper reservations			
Accommodation (per week × weeks)			
Food: self-catering (per week)			
Food: eating out (per week)			
Local transport (buses, trams, taxis)			
Travel insurance (see Part 3)			
Health preparation (vaccines, appointments, extra medicines)			
Phone and data (eSIM, roaming)			
Activities, entry fees, classes			
Home costs while away (bills, pet care, plant care)			
Contingency (a tenth of the total is a reasonable rule of thumb)			
Total			

- **Long stays are cheaper per night.** Many apartment listings show weekly and monthly rates that are well below seven or thirty times the nightly rate. Ask the owner directly if the discount is not shown.
- **Self-catering changes the arithmetic.** A kitchen and a market turn eating out from a daily cost into an occasional pleasure.
- **Off-season is the biggest lever.** The same apartment in May or October is often a fraction of its August price, and the town is quieter.
- **Tell your bank you are travelling** and know how you will get cash. The US State Department's advice for older travellers includes both: alert your bank before you go, and look into where it is safe to use cash machines (ATMs) where you are going.

- **This is general information, not financial advice.** How you fund a long trip, from savings, pension income or elsewhere, is a question for you and, if you want it, a regulated adviser.

Worksheet 3: my money rules for this trip

Total budget I am comfortable with: £ / \$

What I will not do to fund it (borrow, dip into an emergency fund, etc.):

How I will pay abroad (card, cash, both) and what I will do if a card is lost:

Who at home can move money for me if I need it:

Spent so far (update weekly during the trip): £ / \$

Long-stay accommodation: the options

Option	Good for	The question to ask first
Apartment rental (through a platform or a local agency)	Kitchen, space, a neighbourhood. The default for most one-place stays.	Is there a lift, and how many steps to the door? Is the weekly or monthly rate shown?
Aparthotel (serviced apartment with reception)	A kitchen plus someone on the desk. Reassuring for a first solo trip.	What is included: cleaning, linen, breakfast? Is there a minimum stay discount?
House-sitting	Free or near-free accommodation in exchange for looking after a home and often pets.	Exactly what is expected each day, and what happens if I am unwell or need to leave early?
Home exchange	Swapping homes, at the same time or by taking turns. Costs little beyond a membership.	Are we both insured for guests, and what are the house rules on both sides, in writing?
University halls (out of term)	Cheap, central, simple rooms in university towns during vacations.	Which weeks are available, and is the room en suite?
Monastery, convent or retreat guesthouse	Quiet, inexpensive, often beautiful. Sometimes single rooms only.	Are there curfews, shared meals or expectations about participation?
Farm stay or agriturismo	Countryside, food, a host. Good with grandchildren.	How far to the nearest shop and bus? Do we need a car?
Long-let through a local letting agent	For a month or more, often cheaper than platforms and with a local contact.	What deposit, what contract, and what is the notice period?

Rental scams: the three checks

The US Federal Trade Commission (FTC) warns about vacation rental fraud, including hijacked listings and properties that do not exist, and about listings for premium properties at suspiciously low prices. Its advice, which applies anywhere: research before you commit; verify that the property exists, for instance by calling the front desk or the local tourist office; get the cancellation policy in writing before you pay; and pay by credit card or another secure method, never by wire transfer, gift cards or cryptocurrency, which cannot be reversed. Anyone who pressures you to decide quickly is telling you something.

Rail passes, explained at the level you need

There are three passes most readers of this workbook will meet. They change their prices and conditions often, so treat this as orientation and read the official pages before you buy. Sometimes a pass is a bargain; sometimes two or three point-to-point tickets booked in advance are cheaper and simpler. Do the sums for your own itinerary.

Pass	Who it is for	What we found on the official page	Check before buying
Interrail Global Pass	Residents of the participating European countries (which includes the UK)	Covers 33 countries. Senior (60 and over) and youth (12 to 27) prices are available; it is issued as a mobile pass; most high-speed and night trains require a reservation at an additional cost; residents can use it in their own country for one outbound and one inbound journey.	Which pass length (a number of travel days within a period, or continuous) fits your plan; reservation costs on the trains you actually want; 1st or 2nd class.
Eurail Global Pass	Residents of countries outside Europe (for instance the US, Canada, Australia)	Sold through eurail.com and covers the same network as Interrail. The senior discount is 10% off if you are 60 or over on the date you start your trip; if you are 59 on your first day of travel you need an adult pass.	As for Interrail: pass length, reservations, class. Both passes are sold in flexible and continuous versions.
Amtrak USA Rail Pass	Anyone travelling long distance in the US	At the time of writing: 10 rides (segments) over 30 days for \$499, in Coach class. Not valid on Acela, Auto Train or certain Thruway buses. The pass is valid for 120 days after purchase; once you take the first segment you have 30 days to use the rest. Each segment must be booked, and there is a limited number of pass seats on each train.	Whether ten segments in thirty days suits a slow trip (it may be more than you need); whether sleeper upgrades are possible on your route; the two-round-trips restriction between the same two stations.
Point-to-point tickets, booked early	Everyone	No pass to learn. Advance fares on many European and US routes are cheapest weeks ahead and rise closer to the date.	Whether the saving from a pass beats three or four early-booked tickets for your route. Often it does not, for a stay-put trip.

- **Reservations are the hidden cost.** On many high-speed and overnight trains a pass gets you on board only with a paid reservation. Budget for them and book them early; the pass does not guarantee a seat.
- **Sleeper trains suit slow travel.** A night train turns a travel day into a night's sleep and an arrival at breakfast. Book well ahead and ask for a lower berth if steps are an issue.
- **Rail assistance exists.** UK and many European operators, and Amtrak, provide booked assistance for passengers with reduced mobility. Ask when you book, not on the platform.
- **The pass is not the point.** It is a tool for a certain kind of trip. If your trip is one town for a month, you may not need one at all.

Part 3: Insurance and health

This is the part people skip, and it is the part that decides whether a bad day abroad is an inconvenience or a disaster. None of it is complicated. All of it needs to start early.

Travel insurance after fifty, and declaring conditions honestly

The single most important rule is to declare every medical condition the insurer asks about, completely and truthfully. MoneyHelper, the UK government-backed money guidance service, lists what insurers generally count as a pre-existing condition: any condition you are waiting for an operation on; any condition you are awaiting test results for; any condition, even a minor one, that you have seen a doctor about in the past year; and any serious condition, such as cancer, heart trouble or respiratory problems, that you have ever had. Insurers commonly look back two years and sometimes longer. If you leave something out and then need to claim, the claim can be rejected, and MoneyHelper is blunt about what that can mean: not getting the treatment you need quickly, or facing large medical bills or the cost of getting home. Declaring costs more in premium. Not declaring costs more in every other way.

Worksheet 4: my insurance checklist	Answer / done
Every condition, medication and recent appointment listed, so the medical screening call is easy	
Single-trip or annual multi-trip? (Annual policies often cap the length of any one trip; a month may exceed it)	
Maximum trip length on the policy covers my whole stay, including travel days	
Activities covered (walking above a certain altitude, cycling, swimming, anything the policy calls 'hazardous')	
Cancellation cover is enough for what I have paid in advance	
Medical repatriation (being brought home) is included	
Baggage and gadget cover, if I care about it	
If I was declined or quoted a very high premium: tried the MoneyHelper travel insurance directory (UK), a broker, or a nearer destination or shorter trip	
Policy number and the 24-hour emergency line saved in my phone and written on paper	

- **UK: the MoneyHelper directory.** If you have a health condition and are struggling to find cover, MoneyHelper runs a free directory of specialist insurers, all authorised and regulated by the Financial Conduct Authority (FCA). It does not give quotes; you contact each firm directly. MoneyHelper notes that, depending on age or condition, cover may still be expensive or unavailable, but it is the right first port of call.
- **UK: the GHIC.** The UK Global Health Insurance Card is free, lasts up to five years and lets you get necessary state healthcare in the EEA and some other countries on the same basis as a resident, including treatment for long-term or pre-existing conditions. It does not cover being flown home, private treatment or mountain rescue, and, in the NHS's own words, it does not replace travel and medical insurance. Apply on the NHS website; never through a site that charges.
- **US: Medicare does not travel.** The US State Department's guidance for travellers aged 65 and over states that Medicare and Medicaid do not cover you abroad. The CDC advises considering supplemental travel health insurance and medical evacuation insurance. Check what your existing plan covers overseas, and read the exclusions.

- **Everyone:** read the policy wording on pre-existing conditions, trip length and age limits before you pay, not after. Where you have a choice, buy insurance when you book, so that cancellation cover starts straight away.

Health preparation: six to eight weeks out

NHS Fit for Travel, the travel health service for the UK public, says that ideally you should book a travel health appointment six to eight weeks before you travel, so that any vaccines have time to become fully effective, and that a professional risk assessment is particularly advisable for older people and those with long-term conditions. It adds that if your trip is sooner, it is never too late to seek advice. The CDC gives the same message for US travellers: see a doctor at least a month before you go and discuss your history, your medicines and your itinerary.

1. **Book the appointment now**, with your GP practice (family doctor) or a travel clinic. Take your vaccination records, a list of medicines and your itinerary.
2. **Ask about vaccines for your destination and about routine ones.** The CDC notes that more than half of tetanus cases in the US are in people over 65 and suggests considering a booster before travel. Whether that applies to you is a question for the clinician, not for a workbook.
3. **Sort medicines for the whole trip plus spare days.** The CDC advises packing enough for the trip plus a few days' extra in case of delays, in original containers, with a copy of the prescription, in your hand luggage. Ask your prescriber early; a month's supply for a month away may need arranging.
4. **Carry a letter listing conditions, allergies and medicines**, as the US State Department suggests, and know the generic names of what you take, because pharmacies abroad may not recognise brand names.
5. **Check whether your medicines are legal at your destination.** Some common prescriptions are restricted in some countries. Your country's foreign travel advice pages for the destination will say.
6. **Plan for the journey.** The NHS lists a long journey of more than four hours by plane, car or train as a risk factor for deep vein thrombosis (DVT), and advises wearing loose clothing, drinking plenty of water, avoiding alcohol and walking around when possible. If you are over sixty or have had a clot before, ask your GP whether compression stockings are appropriate for you.

Worksheet 5: my health preparation

Travel health appointment booked for:

Vaccines advised and dates:

Medicines needed for the trip (name, generic name, quantity):

Prescriber asked for extended supply on:

Letter from prescriber requested / received:

Anything I need to check about carrying my medicines into the destination:

Pharmacy near my accommodation (name, hours):

This is general information, not medical advice. Your GP or travel clinic knows your situation.

Part 4: The practical layer

Packing light: one bag you can lift

The test is simple: can you lift your bag into a train's overhead rack, or carry it up two flights of stairs, without help and without hurting yourself? If not, it is too heavy, however long the trip. A month needs no more than a week, because you will wash things. Long-stay accommodation almost always has a washing machine or a launderette nearby; ask before you book.

- ☐ A bag with wheels and a shoulder strap, or a rucksack you have carried loaded for an hour at home
- ☐ Clothes for seven days, in colours that all go together, in layers rather than bulk
- ☐ Two pairs of shoes, both broken in: one for walking, one for everything else
- ☐ A light waterproof jacket, whatever the forecast
- ☐ Medicines for the whole trip plus spare days, in hand luggage, with the prescription copy and the letter
- ☐ Passport (checked for validity, see below), insurance documents, GHIC if you have one, printed and on your phone
- ☐ Phone, charger, a plug adaptor, a small power bank
- ☐ Reading glasses and a spare pair; sunglasses; a hat
- ☐ A small first-aid kit: plasters (bandages), blister plasters, any over-the-counter items you rely on
- ☐ A reusable water bottle and a folding shopping bag
- ☐ A notebook and a pen (see Part 6)
- ☐ Photocopies of passport and cards, kept separately from the originals; the same as photos on your phone
- ☐ A door wedge or small alarm if you sleep more soundly with one
- ☐ Nothing 'just in case' that you have not used in the last year

For walking holidays, the Ramblers' packing guidance adds: a daypack of 20 to 35 litres for full-day walks; comfortable hiking boots or trail shoes with moisture-wicking layers; spare socks; a warm hat and gloves for the hills; a map, compass and map case; an in-case-of-emergency card with medical details; a first-aid kit with blister plasters; at least a litre of water; a whistle and head torch; waterproof jacket and trousers even when the forecast is good; and, in warm weather, sunscreen, insect repellent, sunglasses and a brimmed hat. Their warning about a bigger pack applies to every kind of bag: the temptation is to fill it with extras that make for a back-breaking load.

Passports and entry rules: the checks that catch people out

- **UK passport holders visiting the Schengen area** (most of the EU plus some neighbours): gov.uk's country pages state that your passport must have been issued less than ten years before the date you arrive and must expire at least three months after the date you plan to leave the Schengen area. You can visit without a visa for up to 90 days in any 180-day period, and earlier visits count. A month-long stay is fine; two months, then another month soon after, needs adding up.
- **The EU Entry/Exit System (EES)** is being introduced at Schengen borders. Gov.uk explains that you may need to register biometric details, fingerprints and a photo, on entry, and that the record is valid for three years. Expect the first crossing to take longer.

- **US passport holders:** the State Department's advice for older travellers is to ensure your passport is valid for at least six months beyond your return date and to check the destination pages for whether you need a visa or an electronic travel authorisation.
- **Everyone:** electronic travel authorisations are spreading (the UK, the US and the EU all have or are introducing them). Apply only through the official government site; the FTC warns of imposter sites that charge high fees for what is cheap or free from the government.
- **Register your trip.** US citizens can enrol in the free Smart Traveler Enrollment Program (STEP) to receive safety, health and weather alerts from the local embassy and to help the embassy reach you or your emergency contact in a crisis.

Staying connected

You do not need to be reachable every minute. You do need a phone that works for maps, tickets, translation and the insurer's emergency line, and a way for family to reach you. Three things settle it.

- **Data.** An eSIM (a digital SIM you buy online and install on a compatible phone) lets you buy a local or regional data plan before you leave without swapping cards. Alternatively, check your own provider's roaming terms; some include certain countries, others charge heavily. The State Department's plain advice is worth repeating: verify that your phone will work abroad before you go.
- **Wi-Fi.** The FTC's current view is that because most websites now use encryption, connecting through public Wi-Fi is usually safe; look for the lock symbol or 'https' in the address bar. The bigger risk is fake websites, so type addresses yourself for banking, use strong passwords and two-factor authentication, and keep your phone's software up to date before you leave.
- **Check-ins.** Agree a rhythm with one person at home: a message every evening, or every Sunday, whatever suits. A missed check-in then means something, and the rest of the time nobody worries. Share your itinerary and accommodation details with that person, as the State Department suggests, and give them the insurer's number.

Worksheet 6: my connection plan

Data: eSIM / roaming / local SIM, bought from:

My home check-in person and rhythm:

They have: my itinerary ☐ accommodation addresses ☐ insurer's emergency line ☐ a copy of my passport ☐

Offline maps downloaded for:

Emergency number at my destination (it is not always 999 or 911):

UK: nearest British embassy or consulate; US: nearest US embassy or consulate, and STEP enrolled ☐

Safety and scams for travellers

Most trips pass without incident, and most of what goes wrong is small: a lost card, an overcharged taxi, a booking that was not quite what the photos showed. The habits below deal with the small things and make the rare serious ones much less likely. The scam list draws on the FTC's consumer guidance, which is as relevant in Lisbon as in Louisiana.

The situation	The warning sign	What to do
A 'free' or very cheap holiday, by phone, email or online	You have to pay something to claim it; you did not ask for the call; there is pressure to decide now	Hang up or delete. Nothing genuine needs a decision today.

The situation	The warning sign	What to do
A rental listing at a remarkable price	No exact address; the owner wants a wire transfer, gift cards or crypto; the listing is on a platform but they ask you to pay off it	Verify the property exists; pay by card through the platform; get the cancellation terms in writing.
A visa, travel-authorisation or passport-renewal site	Fees far above the official ones; a web address that is not the government's	Go to the official government site directly. Legitimate authorisations are cheap or free.
A taxi with no meter, or a 'helpful' stranger at the station	Reluctance to state a price; being steered away from the official rank	Use the official rank or a booked app; agree the price or insist on the meter before moving.
A card machine held out of sight, or a cash machine that looks tampered with	You cannot see the amount; a loose or bulky card slot; someone standing close	Ask to see the screen; use machines inside banks in daylight; cover the keypad.
A message 'from your bank' or 'from the embassy' while you are away	Urgency; a link; a request for codes or passwords	Do not click. Call the number on the back of your card or on the official website.

- Keep a second card and some cash somewhere other than your wallet.
- Carry a copy of your passport rather than the original when you can; keep the original in the accommodation's safe or somewhere secure.
- Know the local emergency number and where the nearest hospital and your embassy or consulate are before you need them.
- If you are scammed, report it: in the UK to Action Fraud, in the US at ReportFraud.ftc.gov, and to your card issuer straight away. Reporting is not embarrassing; it is how the next person is protected.

Part 5: Travelling your way

Solo travel after fifty

Travelling alone in your fifties, sixties or seventies is common, and slow travel suits it particularly well, because a long stay in one place gives you the thing solo travellers most want and most often miss: routine, and the acquaintances that grow from it. The person at the café on the third morning is a nod; by the tenth they know how you take your coffee.

- **Choose accommodation with a human in it** for your first solo trip: an aparthotel, a guesthouse, a homestay attached to a language school. You can go fully independent next time.
- **Book something structured for the first few days.** A class, a walking tour, a course. It gives the week a spine and puts you in a room with people who share an interest.
- **Eat out at lunch rather than dinner** if evenings alone feel long. Lunch is cheaper, brighter and more sociable in most of Europe anyway.
- **Build your daily check-in into the day** rather than treating it as a chore: the evening message home is also your journal entry.
- **Say yes to invitations and no to pressure.** You are old enough to know the difference and to say so plainly.
- **Single supplements are real** but often negotiable on long stays, and rarely apply to apartments. Ask.

Travelling with limited mobility

A slow trip is, in many ways, the accessible trip: one base, short distances, no daily repacking, and time to do things at the pace that suits you. The work is in the questions you ask before you book. 'Accessible' on a listing means nothing until someone has told you, in writing, exactly what it means. The State Department's advice for older travellers puts it simply: find out ahead of time what accessibility accommodations are available at the places you will visit.

Ask about	The precise question	Answer
Getting in	How many steps from the street to the front door, and from the door to the flat? Is there a lift, and how wide is it?	
The bathroom	Walk-in shower or bath? Grab rails? Is there room to turn, and is the toilet raised?	
The bed	Height from the floor? Space on both sides?	
The neighbourhood	How far, on foot, to the nearest shop, café and bus stop, and is it flat?	
Transport	Are local buses or trams step-free? Which stations have lifts? Can I book assistance for trains?	
Equipment	Can I hire a wheelchair, walker, shower stool or mobility scooter locally? From whom?	
Getting there	Have I booked assistance with the railway, airline or ferry, and confirmed it in writing?	

- Book passenger assistance for every leg of the journey, in advance, and keep the confirmation. In the UK this is a single national booking system across train operators; airlines and Amtrak have their own.

- Plan one thing a day, not three. Distance and steps add up, and the point of a long stay is that there is always tomorrow.
- Pack the mobility aids you use at home; it is not the moment to try managing without.
- Tell your insurer about mobility aids and any equipment you are taking, so they are covered.

Travelling with grandchildren

A week with grandchildren inside a longer slow trip can be the best week of it, provided it is planned as its own block with its own rhythm. Children do not do slow in the way adults mean it, but they do repetition and routine gloriously, which is close enough: the same beach, the same playground, the same ice-cream counter every afternoon, and a bedtime that does not move.

- **Accommodation:** ground floor or a lift, a kitchen, a washing machine, a separate room for you. A farm stay or a house with a garden beats a smart flat.
- **Paperwork:** a signed letter from the parents authorising you to travel with the children and to consent to medical treatment, plus copies of the children's passports and any medical information. Some countries ask; all are reassured.
- **Insurance:** the children need their own cover, or to be named on a family policy. Check who is covered before anyone gets on a train.
- **One outing a day, mornings.** Afternoons are for the pool, the park or the sofa. Evenings are short.
- **Let the parents plan the handover** at the start and end, and agree the rules on screens, sweets and bedtime before, not during.
- **Build in a rest day for you** in the middle. Say so out loud. It is not a failing; it is how a good week stays good.

Walking holidays

Walking is the natural pace of slow travel, and a walking holiday, whether a route walked over a fortnight with luggage transferred, or a base with day walks from it, is the form most people mean by it. The one piece of advice that matters more than any other comes from a Ramble Worldwide tour leader's guidance on fitness: check the grade and, most importantly, the distance you will typically walk in a day, then find a willing friend and walk that distance. Do it several times, on similar terrain, in the boots you will wear. If it feels fine, the holiday will.

- **Choose a grade below the one you think you can do**, particularly for the first trip. The same guidance suggests two-grade holidays, which offer an easier and a harder route each day, and slower-paced options for those who want the scenery without the mileage.
- **Luggage transfer** turns a long-distance path into something manageable: you carry a daypack, the bag goes ahead by van. Most organised routes offer it.
- **Poles** save knees on descents. Learn to use them at home, not on the first hill.
- **Rest days** every third or fourth day are part of the plan, not a concession.
- **Joint replacements are common among walkers**, as the same guidance notes, and need not put you off; speak to your GP or physiotherapist about what is sensible for you and build up gradually.
- **Check with your GP (family doctor)** before taking on more walking than you are used to, especially if you have a heart condition, high blood pressure or joint problems.

House-sitting and home exchange

Both turn accommodation from the largest cost of a long trip into almost nothing, and both put you in a real home in a real neighbourhood, which is what slow travel is for. They are not free in the sense of

costing no effort. A house-sit is a job with a bed attached; an exchange is a relationship of trust that starts with your own house being spotless.

- **House-sitting:** read the listing as a job description. Pets that need walking twice a day, plants that need watering, a garden in August: these shape your days. Ask what happens if you fall ill. Speak to the owners by video before agreeing. Get the arrangement, dates and expectations in writing.
- **Home exchange:** check your home insurance covers guests, and ask them the same. Agree house rules, utilities, cleaning and what happens with breakages in writing. Exchange local knowledge: the doctor, the good bakery, the bin day.
- **Both:** platforms charge a membership rather than a nightly fee. Compare the annual cost with one week's rental and you will see why people join.
- **Both:** start with a shorter arrangement near home, to learn the form before committing to a month abroad.

The off-season

The single best decision in this workbook, for most people over fifty, is to travel when others do not. The weeks either side of the school holidays and the shoulder months of spring and autumn bring lower prices, emptier trains, shorter queues, milder heat, and locals with time to talk. Winter in the Mediterranean and summer in the mountains are the classic versions.

Off-season advantage	The trade-off	How to check
Lower accommodation prices, often by a large margin	Some places close entirely between seasons	Email the tourist office and two restaurants; ask what is open in your month
Fewer people; a town that belongs to its residents	Reduced bus and ferry timetables	Look up the timetable for your dates, not the summer one
Milder weather for walking	Shorter daylight and more rain in some regions	Check sunrise and sunset times and average rainfall for the month
Easier to get rail reservations and assistance	Engineering works are often scheduled off-season	Check the operator's planned works page before booking
Locals with time to talk	Fewer organised activities and classes	Ask what runs year-round; libraries, walking groups and choirs usually do

Part 6: Keeping well and keeping a record

Keeping fit on the road

A slow trip is not a rest from activity; done right, it is the most active month of your year, because walking replaces driving and the days are your own. The NHS guidelines for adults aged 65 and over ask for at least 150 minutes of moderate activity a week (you can talk but not sing), activities that improve strength, balance and flexibility on at least two days a week, and breaking up long periods of sitting. A long stay in a walkable town makes the first almost automatic. The second needs ten minutes and a bit of floor.

- **Walk somewhere every day**, with a destination: the market, the far end of the beach, the next village. Twenty minutes each way is 40 of the 150.

- **Ten minutes of strength and balance, twice a week, in the room:** sit-to-stand from a chair, calf raises holding the counter, standing on one leg while the kettle boils, a wall press-up. Whatever you do at home, keep doing it away; there is no need for equipment.
- **Break up the sitting,** especially on travel days. On a train of more than four hours, walk the corridor every hour, flex your ankles, and drink water rather than wine, as the NHS advises for reducing DVT risk.
- **Swim if there is water.** Pools, lakes and sea are the reason many people over fifty go where they go, and swimming is kind to joints.
- **Check with your GP (family doctor)** before increasing your activity significantly, particularly if you have a heart condition, high blood pressure or have been inactive for a while. Then go and enjoy it.

Journaling and photography: a record you will actually look at

The trips that stay with you are the ones you wrote down. Not a diary of what you did, which is dull to write and duller to read, but a page each evening of what you noticed. A slow trip gives you the time; the notebook in the packing list is for this.

Five-minute evening prompts

One thing I saw today that I had not seen before.

One thing somebody said, and who they were.

What I ate that was worth remembering.

What surprised me about the ordinary (the shops, the buses, the manners).

What I would tell someone coming here next year.

How my body felt today, honestly.

- **Photograph the ordinary.** The bread, the bus stop, the view from the kitchen window every morning of the stay. The famous view has been photographed better by others; the kitchen window is yours.
- **Take fewer pictures and look at them sooner.** Choose ten each week, and delete the near-duplicates while you still remember which was best.
- **Print something when you get home.** A small book of forty photographs and a few lines of the journal costs little and will be looked at more than any folder on a computer.
- **Write the last page on the train home,** while it is still true.

The 12-week countdown

The countdown runs backwards from departure day, in fortnights. Each block lists the tasks for that fortnight; tick the box when a task is done and note anything you learned. If you start with fewer than twelve weeks to go, do the earlier blocks first and faster: the insurance and health tasks are the ones that cannot be compressed.

12 weeks before: decide

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Decide	Complete Worksheets 1 and 2. Choose the kind of trip, the place (or up to three), the month and the length.	☐
Passport	Check passport issue and expiry dates against the rules for your destination (UK to Schengen: issued less than ten years before arrival, expires three months after leaving; US: six months beyond return is the State Department's advice). Renew now if in doubt.	☐
Insurance	Write out every condition, medicine and recent appointment ready for the medical screening. Get two or three quotes; try the MoneyHelper directory (UK) if declined.	☐
Health	Book the travel health appointment for six to eight weeks before departure (NHS Fit for Travel's guidance). Ask your prescriber about an extended supply.	☐
Budget	Fill in the budget template (Part 2) with your first estimates. Complete Worksheet 3, the money rules.	☐
Companion	If travelling with someone, compare Worksheet 1 scores and settle the shape of the trip together.	☐

10 weeks before: book the bones

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Beds	Shortlist three long-stay options. Ask the precise questions from Part 2 (and the mobility table if relevant), in writing. Book one, by card, with the cancellation terms saved.	☐
Trains	Do the sums: rail pass versus point-to-point. Read the official pass page. Book advance fares or the pass; book seat and sleeper reservations as soon as they open.	☐
Insurance	Buy the policy so cancellation cover starts. Save the policy number and emergency line to your phone and on paper.	☐
Entry	Check gov.uk or travel.state.gov for your destination: visa, electronic travel authorisation, any medicines that are restricted. Apply for authorisations only through the official site.	☐
GHIC / STEP	UK: apply for or renew your GHIC on the NHS site (free). US: enrol in STEP (free).	☐
Home	Arrange pet care, plant care and post. Tell a neighbour.	☐

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
	If house-sitting or exchanging, confirm dates and expectations in writing.	

8 weeks before: health and body

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Clinic	Attend the travel health appointment. Note vaccines given and any dates for second doses.	☐
Medicines	Request the full-trip supply plus spare days; ask for a letter listing conditions, allergies and medicines with generic names.	☐
Walking	Start walking the daily distance your trip will ask of you, in the shoes you will wear. For a walking holiday, walk the typical day's distance at least three times before you go.	☐
Strength	Settle a ten-minute strength-and-balance routine you can do in a rented room. Do it twice a week from now.	☐
Assistance	If you need passenger assistance on trains, ferries or flights, book it for every leg now and keep the confirmations.	☐
Grandchildren	If they are coming: agree dates, handover, rules and paperwork with their parents. Check their insurance.	☐

6 weeks before: the local layer

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Learn	Twenty phrases in the local language: greetings, please and thank you, numbers, 'I have a condition, here is my letter', 'where is the pharmacy'.	☐
Map	Download offline maps of the town and region. Mark the accommodation, the nearest pharmacy, hospital, station and market.	☐
Structure	Book one structured thing for the first few days: a class, a guided walk, a market tour. Leave the rest of the calendar empty.	☐
Season	Email the tourist office: what is open in your month, what the bus timetable looks like, any events or closures.	☐
Money	Tell your bank the dates and countries. Check card fees abroad. Decide on a second card and where you will keep it.	☐
Phone	Check your phone works abroad; choose eSIM, roaming or a local SIM. Update the phone's software. Set up two-factor authentication on banking and email.	☐

4 weeks before: paperwork and people

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Documents	Photocopy passport, cards, insurance, GHIC, prescriptions and the medicines letter. One set in the bag, one at home, photos on the phone.	☐
Check-in	Agree the check-in rhythm with your home contact and give them the itinerary, accommodation details and the insurer's number (Worksheet 6).	☐
Bag	Pack a trial bag from the checklist in Part 4. Carry it up two flights of stairs. Remove things until you can.	☐
Confirm	Re-confirm accommodation, assistance bookings and any luggage transfer, in writing.	☐
Journal	Buy the notebook. Write the first page: what you hope this trip will be. You will read it on the way home.	☐
Budget	Update the budget template with real figures now that the big items are booked. Note the contingency.	☐

2 weeks before: the final layer

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Medicines	Collect the full supply. Pack it in hand luggage, in original containers, with the prescription copy and letter.	☐
Advice	Re-read the official travel advice for your destination for any changes: entry rules, health notices, safety.	☐
Tickets	Load rail tickets, passes and reservations onto the phone and print a paper copy of each.	☐
Home	Confirm pet and plant care, cancel deliveries, set a light timer, give keys to the neighbour.	☐
Body	Keep walking daily. Do not start anything new this fortnight; the aim is to arrive rested.	☐
Cash	Get a small amount of local currency for the first day: a coffee, a bus, a tip.	☐

The last week: calm

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Pack	Pack properly from the checklist. Weigh the bag. Lift it. Nothing 'just in case'.	☐
Travel day	Plan the journey to the station or airport with time to spare. Loose clothes, water bottle, a book. On any leg over four hours, walk every hour.	☐
Fridge	Empty it. Bins out. Heating set. Water off if away for the month and the season warrants.	☐
Phone	Fully charged, power bank charged, eSIM installed or roaming confirmed, offline maps checked one last time.	☐
Tell	Message your check-in person: leaving tomorrow, first check-in on arrival.	☐

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Sleep	Early night. The trip starts rested or it starts tired, and the first week is set by which.	☐

The on-trip weekly rhythm

Once you arrive, the countdown stops and a rhythm begins. This is one week; repeat it as many times as you are there. It is deliberately light. The spaces between the tasks are the holiday.

A week in one place

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Monday	Market or shop for the week. Long walk with a destination. Ten minutes of strength and balance. Evening: journal and check-in.	☐
Tuesday	The structured thing, if this is the week for it (class, guided walk). Lunch out. Afternoon free.	☐
Wednesday	A day trip by local bus or train to somewhere small. Back before dark. Journal.	☐
Thursday	A quiet day: library, café, a bench, a swim. Ten minutes of strength and balance. Update the budget with the week's spending.	☐
Friday	The week's longer outing: a hill, a coast path, a full day's walk. Rest afterwards. Evening check-in.	☐
Saturday	Do again the thing you liked most this week. Choose the week's ten photographs. Delete the rest.	☐
Sunday	Nothing planned. Laundry. Write the week's page: what I noticed, what I would tell someone. Plan next week loosely.	☐

If the week wobbles

Tired: drop Wednesday and Friday; keep the daily short walk. Lonely: book a second structured thing and eat lunch out three days running. Unwell: use the pharmacy you marked in week six, call the insurer's line if it is more than a cold, and tell your check-in person. Bored: you chose the wrong town, which is useful to know; move one stop down the line for the last week. Homesick: common somewhere in the second week, and it passes.

When you get home

- ☐ Fill in the 'actual' column of the budget while the receipts are in your bag
- ☐ Write the last page of the journal on the train home, and read the first page
- ☐ Print the forty best photographs with a few lines each
- ☐ Note what you would change: the town, the month, the bag, the length
- ☐ Thank the check-in person, the neighbour and anyone who looked after the house
- ☐ Book the travel health appointment for the next trip if a second dose or booster is due
- ☐ Decide, within a fortnight, where and when the next slow trip will be, and write it in the diary

What happens next

- **If it worked**, book the next one before the glow fades, in a different season or a different kind of trip from the eight in Part 1.
- **If it half worked**, change one thing: the town, the month, the length or the company. Not all four.
- **If it did not work**, you learned something for the price of a month somewhere else, which is not nothing. Write down what, and try the opposite kind of trip next.

The newsletter. Once a week at dontdieretired.com we send a short, practical email for people over fifty who intend to keep going: something to try, some evidence explained without the jargon, and ideas for the next trip. No hype, and you can leave any time. **Our other workbooks.** A slow trip goes better on a body that walks easily and a mind that likes to learn. The 30-Day Restart and Strong at 60 are for the body; Sharp is for the mind; Reconnect is for the company. All are at dontdieretired.com.

Before you close the book

Fill in Worksheet 1 tonight.

Check your passport dates now.

Book the travel health appointment this week.

“Go somewhere. Stay long enough to be recognised. Walk every day. Write it down. Come home rested. That is the whole method.” — Slow Travel After 50

Sources consulted

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